

Enteroctopus dolfeini

Giant Pacific octopus

Occurrence 1 sp. in the north Pacific Ocean, down to depths of 2,500 ft (750 m); mostly on the seabed



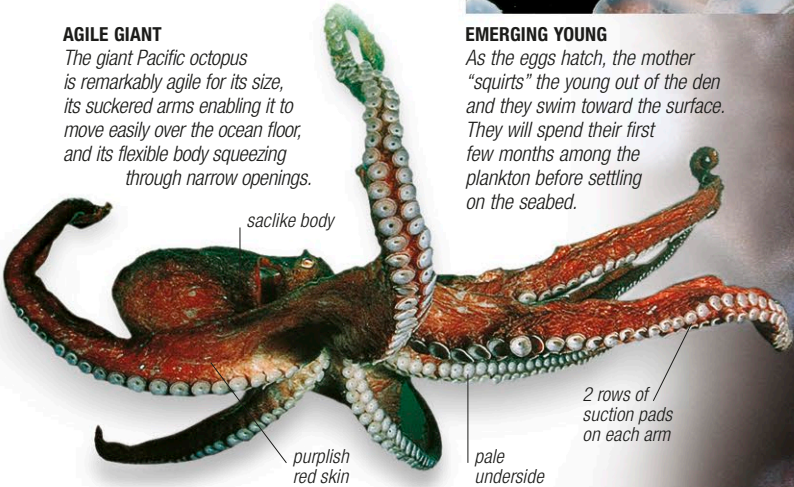
The largest species of octopus in the world, the giant Pacific octopus usually grows to about 9¾ ft (3 m) in length and weighs up to 600 lb (272 kg). It lives on the rim of the north Pacific Ocean, from Japan up to the Aleutian Islands and south to California, where it crawls about on the bottom, using its long, sucker-covered arms. It seeks out rocky dens on the seabed, under boulders or in crevices; youngsters will often dig holes under rocks in sand or gravel. Here, the octopus can take refuge from predators—seals, sea otters, sharks, and other large fishes—too big to slip through the den mouth. Foraging mainly at night, this giant octopus looks especially for crabs and lobsters, but also takes shrimps and shellfish, smaller

octopuses, and fishes. Often it will return to its den to feed, depositing empty shells and other inedible fragments of prey in piles at the entrance. Like its relatives, this octopus mostly lives alone, except for a brief period (which may occur at any time of the year) when adults come together for mating. The male deposits sperm packets up to 3¼ ft (1 m) long in the female's mantle cavity, by means of a specially modified arm. The female lays her eggs in a den, and will tend them until they hatch, which may take as long as 8 months, depending on the temperature of the water. She will not feed in all this time—and will die soon after her young emerge. Lifespans range up to 4 years.



AGILE GIANT

The giant Pacific octopus is remarkably agile for its size, its suckered arms enabling it to move easily over the ocean floor, and its flexible body squeezing through narrow openings.

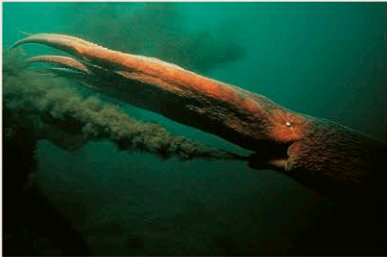


EMERGING YOUNG

As the eggs hatch, the mother "squirts" the young out of the den and they swim toward the surface. They will spend their first few months among the plankton before settling on the seabed.

DEFENSE AND ATTACK

When threatened, the giant Pacific octopus may change color, or flee hidden by an inky cloud. When it catches prey, it grasps it firmly and pulls it apart, bites it open, or breaks through the shell with its beak.



FLEEING FROM DANGER

When a predator gives chase, the octopus ejects an inky substance that forms a dark cloud in the water. Hidden from view, the octopus can swiftly make its escape.

DEALING WITH A CRAB

Holding a crab firmly in its suckers, the octopus makes a hole in the shell with its beak, then injects saliva to liquefy connective tissue so that meat can be extracted.

DEVOTED MOTHER

The female lays many thousands of eggs and stays with them for 5–8 months, guarding them until they hatch. She continuously washes them with a stream of water from her funnel, and grooms them with her arms to keep them free of parasites.